

The view of the Taj Mahal from the Agra Fort. Picture by Kanithapithan

These inventions aside, is the story really true? Did the Shah love his wife so deeply? While the idea that the Taj is an "elegy in marble" and a "tear ... on the cheek of time" is certainly the dominant narrative about the Taj - possibly because it continues to entrance millions - it has never been the only one. Perhaps the most critical author of the site to write in English was Aldous Huxley, who argued that the building, while grand in scale, was built of inferior materials and in a weak, derivative style. Huxley also believed that the Taj Mahal was at most a grand propaganda piece for an emperor who should be better known for his ruthlessness than for his romance[3]. Advocates of that approach note that in the early 1630s, Jahan had just consolidated his control over a spectacular and growing empire, and that the new ruler probably wanted to construct some type of monument that would be a symbol of his power, the way the ancient Egyptian pharaohs frequently tried to outdo their predecessors with new pyramids. If so, something on the scale of the Taj